

Episode 68: Once Upon a Time... (45) – *Dragon Ball Z: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans* and Final Days with My Mother

Recently my wife has been troubled by nightmares. When I asked, it's apparently dreams about me getting involved with some new religion and not coming home.

"So am I some kind of guru?"

"No, just a low-ranking member"

Oh, I see (bitter laugh).

"And you're wearing something like white clothes making something"

Hmm... (bitter laugh).

Could that be making anime? I have been coming home in the early morning lately (sweat).

It's a mystery.

Well then.

1992. Looking at my work chronology, this year I was involved in three theatrical works (two released that year), completed one video work (*Crying Freeman: Senjou no Kishimojin*), handled colour direction for one TV series episode (*Dragon Quest: Dai no Daibouken*), and did some part-time work on several NHK *Minna no Uta* episodes... It was a year when I got to work on truly various projects.

I think from the previous year and around this year, the works I could participate in increased, work volume kept growing, and I've continued at roughly the same intensity to this day. It feels like the beginning year of that flow.

In 1992, the second theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* was the summer release *Dragon Ball Z: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans* (極限バトル!!三大超サイヤ人). Director Kikuchi Kazuhito, animation director Maeda Minoru, art director Nagasaki Hitoshi - a 60-minute work.

Around this time, "Toei Anime Fair" combined about three theatrical works for screening during spring and summer vacation seasons, and this *Dragon Ball Z* was one such film. Incidentally, the simultaneous screenings were *Dragon Quest: Dai no Daibouken - Buchiyabure!! Shinsei Rokudaishougun* and *Rokudenashi Blues*... I don't remember them (bitter laugh).

From spring theatrical release to summer was four months. Honestly the schedule wasn't very generous, but by this time staff were gradually getting used to making theatrical works on such short schedules. This time too, finishing work was outsourced to Manila studios while there was leeway, with the latter half asking Korean productions for animation + finishing work.

As usual, production schedules fell behind smoothly (bitter laugh), and the volume requested from Korean productions kept increasing. As I wrote previously, requesting Korean productions = Taiyo Shikisai paints. Learning from spring *Dragon Ball Z* reflections, I gradually prepared, but the more I thought and created conversion colour directions by replacing paints, the wider the gap between Taiyo Shikisai colours and STAC paints became. "If only everything could be made with Taiyo Shikisai colours, how much easier it would be!" Such conflicts constantly swirled in my head.

Around that time, there was one major event in my family. My mother's death. My mother, who had been hospitalised with cancer in early spring, passed away in early June during this theatrical work's crucial production phase.

Daily routine continued: first showing my face at my mother's bedside in the morning, entering the studio at noon for work. Returning to the hospital before evening visiting hours ended, then back to the studio until early morning. Such days continued.

Eventually in the early hours of a day in early June, my mother passed away. I took just two days off for wake and funeral, then continued with this theatrical version's colour direction and inspection. For better or worse, there was no replacement for me in this theatrical production. That's this job. Because of this, I remember working quite matter-of-factly.

Every work has memories associated with its production, but memories of this *Dragon Ball Z: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans* overlap with those final days with my mother, making them somehow poignant.

There was another sad event. The night after finishing my mother's funeral, one message reached me. The news of art director Mukuo Takashi's death.

I knew Mukuo-san had been hospitalised for a long time, but he passed away during this same period. I attended the wake held the next day. The steadily falling June rain blurred that wake's scenes, making them quite memorable.

This was the first half of 1992, when I was 29. What awaited me was an even bigger theatrical work - a full two-hour feature.

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